The danse of lightness and intensity: reflection on the duality of Dharamshala

The experience of social relations is shared through light yet quite deep connection. Deep in the sense that there is a genuine wish to know and understand, but light in the sense that emotional intensity and seriousness are low.

Light and intense seem opposite, but in this case, they are weaved together to create an open and welcoming setting for social interaction to occur, and therefore social connection, however transitory, to come and go with ease.

Logically this feeds into the concept of individualism, and so whilst not necessarily collectivist, the social setting is not inward facing with barriers to try to break down leading to a free flow of communication.

So whilst connections are obviously not sought to be strong, connections are indeed sought and found, with an underlying understanding of their transitory nature.

This creates the ground for emotions to be shared, and it the sharing of these positive emotions which creates connection. As the emotions are not intense, neither are the interactions, and so there is no sense of burden or heaviness (unless you specifically don't want to interact). This allows for communication to be honest but not deep, which works well as most of the interactions are done in passing. However, with continual reoccurrence of the same (or highly similar) situations again and again throughout the day, stepping into the social space is easy, if you are indeed open and receptive.

The Dance of Lightness and Intensity – reflections on the duality of Dharamshala

Interactions were characterised by a lightness which fostered openness and ease. While the emotional intensity and seriousness of these exchanges may have been low, there was a genuine desire to know and understand one another (assuming both parties wanted to play).

A Light Yet Deep Connection

When wandering around Dharamshala, interactions unfolded with a gentle lightness, nurturing an openness and ease that invited hearts more than heads to engage. Though these exchanges may have lacked the weight of deep emotional intensity, there was a genuine yet brief search to know and understand one another—provided both parties were willing to dance. This duality—where lightness intertwined with a meaningful connection—created a welcoming space for social interactions to thrive. The ability to engage in light-hearted conversations allowed for frequent positive emotions due to the frequency of which such encounters were offered, all while

tempering the heavy reality of witnessing poverty at a depth rarely encountered in Europe.

Though light and intense may seem like opposites, in this context, they complemented each other beautifully. The light nature of interactions encouraged free flow communication, breaking down individualistic barriers easily (again if you were receptive) and created a sense of accessibility. While connections in this setting may not be deeply rooted, they were still valued and sought after. This understanding of the transitory nature of relationships allowed individuals to engage without pressure, promoting an atmosphere of acceptance and positivity. Further, due to the complete lack of serious subjects of conversation based in personal beliefs and opinions, or anything related to work (and therefore by definition work in terms our sense and use of it as the first pillar of identity), the interactions remained meaningful due to the positive emotional base which created connection.

The Role of Shared Emotions in the individualist-collectivist divide

People were not inward-facing. The lack of barriers to communication, which we tend to build in individualistic societies, facilitated a seamless flow of social engagement, creating an environment where connections could form easily, even if only for a brief moment, and created beautiful opportunities to feel and experience positive affect if you were open enough to receiving.

The essence of social interaction lay in the sharing of positive emotions. As interactions remained light and unburdened, communication was easily honestly without the heaviness that often accompanies deeper discussions. This ease allows for a rich tapestry of social exchanges to unfold, even in passing, especially with an awareness of, in interest in, cultural dynamics and differences. The continual recurrence of similar situations throughout the day made stepping into the social space feel natural and inviting, of course if one steps in to it all open and receptive.

By fostering frequent positive affect and minimizing negative emotions, these social dynamics created a nurturing environment for connections to blossom, even if temporarily. In this way, happiness could be experienced easily, despite the emotional (and perhaps moral) weight and desire to compassionately act on the intense poverty continually attracting attention.

Typically, it's the extremes that best illuminate an example, but in this case it was the norm. It was a glimpse into what life could consistently be relationally and socially - without even beginning to incorporate material comfort, any sense of spiritual values and structure, or even ethics. So, while it may not be the entire formula for happiness, it is a sure first step in building a foundation for it.

Thanks, Dharamshala, you were great.

George